DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Is Man Both the Fixer and the Fixed?

Daat Tevunot §76-78

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §76-78 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 26 January 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

§76-77: how does God deal with body and soul?

This shorter class continued section 4 on page 164 of the English book. The Neshamah asks: you have explained the essence of man, the combination of soul and body, and the different periods. In this world the body is sovereign unless the soul fights back; in the world to come the soul will be sovereign. Now explain how God deals with man in these different times, and explain it clearly.

§78: light and concealment

The Sekhel begins with a basic distinction. There are physical entities and spiritual entities, and the physical are far lower. Spiritual entities are full of enlightenment; physical ones are full of darkness and deficiency.

So there are two kinds of creation. One, the soul, is made with great light. The other, the body, is made with very little. The first comes from God shining His countenance, His goodness. The second comes from God withholding His light. It is still called a creation, the Rabbi stressed, but a creation through withdrawal.

He connected this to the blessing "yoser or uvore hoshekh", He forms light and creates darkness. The word yesirah, forming, describes a direct act on which He constantly shines. Beriah, creating, can describe something brought about through withdrawal. Both come from HaKadosh Barukh Hu. "You can't say God's not responsible for the bad in the world. He is. The question is how it comes about."

The Ramhal draws the consequence: spiritual things are engaged with holiness, while physical things care only for the mundane. So much of what people strive for is worthless. "What difference are we to animals really? We eat and we drink." Physical matters on their own are pure darkness, where God hides Himself, while in spiritual matters He shines.

These are the two ways God conducts the whole world: concealment (hester), where He does not reveal the greatness of His glory, and direct shining light (hearah). The human being is built the same way. The body was formed through concealment and withdrawal; the soul through enlightenment. Man is the combination of the two.

A participant cited Kohelet, "hevel havalim", vanity of vanities. The Rabbi agreed that the body by itself is nothing, hevel havalim. Life in the body, the nefesh habehemit, only lets it move. The question is whether you will use your Neshamah, so that hester and hearah coexist, or leave the body's functions as hevel havalim.

The fixer and the fixed

The Rabbi said this touches on a question asked the week before. A human being is both the metakken and the nitkan: the one who repairs and the one who is repaired. The greatest work of art a person can create in his life is his own self.

He brought the Midrash on the verse "vaasitem otam", "you shall do them", referring to the misvot. Hazal play on the spelling and read it "you shall make yourselves". Doing what is right creates your own identity. "You can summarise the Torah in that. Create your identity."

It is in a person's hands which will prevail. If he follows what his eyes and heart desire, then instead of the soul helping and refining the body, the soul is damaged and sinks into darkness. If he overcomes his yeser and does God's will, the soul overpowers the body and refines it. Either way, he is shaping himself.

Are all souls equal?

A participant asked whether souls differ in quality, since people act so differently. The Rabbi first answered with a car. With the same engine you can drive at twenty miles an hour or ninety; it depends how hard you press the accelerator. Pressed further, he said honestly that he does not know whether every soul is given equally, comparing it to the difference between a small one litre engine and a large Mercedes engine. What he does know is that everyone has the potential for his soul to perfect his body.

He brought a well known question. The Torah says there will never be a prophet like Moshe, which is one of the thirteen principles of faith, and yet it is said that every person can become as great as Moshe. The answer is that everyone can maximise his own potential. If you start at 50 you might reach 150; if you start at 0, you can reach 100. Moshe started very high and maximised fully, so no one will be like him. But everyone can make his own 100.

Working together

Another participant pointed out that even Moshe had limitations, and that no one can do alone what God expects; people fulfilling their potential have to join with others, which rarely happens because of arrogance and conceit. The Rabbi called this "an amazing point".

He linked it to the meaning of Adam. The Torah almost always calls him "HaAdam", the man, because Adam represents the collective identity of the human condition. Our duty is to combine our different strengths. He noted that even Moshe was told he was not a speaker, and that God would appoint someone to speak for him.

Summary

- §76-77: the Neshamah asks how God deals with body and soul in this world and the next.

- §78: the soul is created through God's shining light, the body through His withholding of it; both come from Him, as in "yoser or uvore hoshekh".
- God runs the world through light and concealment, and man is built of the same two elements.
- Man is both the fixer and the fixed: "vaasitem otam", make yourselves.
- Everyone can maximise his own potential, as Moshe did his, and people must join together to complete one another.

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